

# Tobias Pfeiffer

## Contact

✉ [tobi@pragtob.info](mailto:tobi@pragtob.info)

☎ +49 160 205 0792

i [pragtob.info](https://pragtob.info)

🐛 [PragTob](https://PragTob.com)

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## About

Staff Software Engineer specializing in high-throughput backend systems, taming complex domains and developer productivity. With a background spanning from **small startups to scaling unicorns**, I combine strong product thinking, effective collaboration and deep systems expertise in **Elixir, Ruby and SQL** helping teams deliver quickly while maintaining long-term sustainability. I lead teams to success by **removing obstacles**, fostering a **culture of collaboration** and **filling the gaps**. I'm also an active member of the developer community through [conference talks](#) and [open source work](#).

## Key Contributions

- Created [benchee](#), the premier benchmarking tool used on the BEAM (1.5k+ stars on GitHub, ~10M downloads)
- Built a high-performance proxy serving ~84M requests/day (~2000 RPS) with a strict 100ms latency budget
- Senior Staff Engineer influencing ~100 engineers during hyper-growth at Remote through architecture guidance and cross-team leadership
- Keynote speaker at Code BEAM EU with the talk "[Going Staff](#)"
- Led incident response & analysis for critical payroll, financial and logistics systems

## Work

[Together.ai](#) (~250 employees)

07/2025 — now

### Senior Engineer

Improving a critical central service (Elixir, PostgreSQL) focused on identity & collaboration while maintaining various clients (TypeScript, Go, Python), helping the company move to an improved model.

- Took ownership of a critical backend service within weeks, formalized architecture & API design, reducing reliance on tribal knowledge while improving the effectiveness of AI agents
- Led cross-team Blocking & Banning initiative, aligning product and engineering, clarifying system dependencies
- Improved reliability and observability by integrating gRPC error tracking, adding missing integration tests to critical paths, correcting metric inaccuracies & improving performance - now we know our P95 is sub millisecond

[Screenverse](#) (~40 employees)

06/2024 — 06/2025

### Senior Engineer

Worked in programmatic digital out of home advertisement using Elixir to ship performant & reliable software.

- Designed & implemented a high-performance caching proxy with a strict 100ms end-to-end latency budget handling ~84M requests/day (~2000 RPS peak) on a single 4-core node using Elixir, GenServer, ETS & Plug
- Used Rust to efficiently parse & transform XML responses as well as adding Redis as more permanent cache to support follow-up requests with a longer life time
- Contributed improvements to libraries across our networking stack (Req, finch, mint)
- Pushed initiatives like developer learning, standardization, test coverage & reducing error fatigue

[Remote](#) (~150 → 1100 employees)

04/2021 — 10/2023

### Senior Staff Engineer - 18 months / Staff Engineer - 13 months

Worked on a big Elixir & Phoenix monolith in HR-tech with a focus on the payments domain, automating processes to ensure safe, quick & reliable payments of millions while improving processes and technology company wide.

- Acted as the most senior engineering individual for long periods during hyper growth, advising teams, reviewing designs, facilitating cross-team decisions & intervening in high-risk changes and situations
- Drove company-wide engineering process improvements (RFC process, branching model)
- Introduced Background Job System (Oban) to guarantee reliable asynchronous processing in a large Phoenix monolith
- Prevented high-risk architectural coupling by redirecting a planned job board feature out of the HRIS monolith into a separate service after system interaction analysis
- Architected & Implemented features to help our payments efficiency and product offering: adding more payment providers, automatic invoice payments, bank integration via PAIN XML to automate payments, enable direct debit for huge sums & allowing non local currencies
- Led incident response for multiple production failures involving payroll and financial processing, coordinating mitigation and post-mortems
- Advocated for hiring non Elixir engineers, setup a training camp and mentored to help them succeed
- Participated in more than 100 interviews during hyper-growth, trained others on interviewing and code challenge reviewing

[Shopify](#) (~8000 employees)

08/2020 — 03/2021

### Staff Developer

Engineering Lead for a team working in Ruby on Rails on topics ranging from local market adaptation, to legal and delivery promise in the e-commerce field.

[Self-employed](#)

08/2019 — 07/2020

### Freelance Leader, Developer & Consultant

Consulting, Teaching and Development.

- Helped a company develop their first Elixir project, introducing the technology to the team
- Loadtested a Rails ecommerce system leading to 100x more concurrent checkouts with fewer servers
- Worked on a complex microservice metrics visualization application in Ruby & NodeJS
- Open Source work on the code coverage tool [SimpleCov](#) sponsored by [Ruby Together](#)
- Consulted on the design, architecture & implementation of an open source project, including implementation

[Liefery](#) (~50 → 150 employees)

01/2017 — 02/2019

### Tech Lead (de facto Head of Engineering)

Led a product department of 15 together with the CTO, handling the day-to-day needs of the team. Built and maintained applications to track shipments, plan tours and manage all required logistics data in Ruby on Rails, Elixir and Phoenix as well as JavaScript (AngularJS, React).

- Helped, mentored & guided colleagues through 1:1s, pairing sessions, pull request reviews and knowledge sharing sessions
- Ran retrospective and iteration meetings, continuously adapting and improving processes
- Architected and designed features with the squads
- Served as interim-CTO during a sabbatical
- Monitored application performance and fixed performance problems
- Screened and interviewed candidates
- Gathered issues from operations and partners to define and triage solutions
- Ran integration projects with customers to onboard them as quickly as possible

[bitcrowd](#) (~10 employees)

01/2015 — 10/2016

### Software Engineer

Built various applications with Ruby on Rails, AngularJS & React in this agency setting. Introduced practices such as retrospectives, Continuous Integration and mentored juniors.

[Self-employed](#)

05/2013 — 09/2018

### Part-Time Freelancer

Occasional projects related to teaching programming, such as an introductory course at Humboldt-University Berlin.

# Community

## Open Source

08/2011 — current

### Creator, Maintainer & Contributor

I live and breathe Open Source and contribute to a variety of projects big and small. This is a selection of bigger projects I maintain or maintained with a strong impact on the eco-system.

- Created [benchee](#), a powerful and extensible benchmarking library widely used in the BEAM ecosystem (1.5k+ github stars, ~10M downloads) for statistically robust benchmarking
- Maintained [simplecov](#), a widely used code coverage library (450M+ downloads)
- Maintained [Shoes](#), an easy to use GUI toolkit written in JRuby (also part of [Google Summer of Code](#))

## Community & Conferences

05/2012 — current

### Speaker, Program Committee Member & Organizer

I've been an active member of the programming community for more than a decade. I have [spoken at conferences](#) such as Øredev, Lambdadays, Polyconf and Full Stack Fest.

- In 2024 I keynoted Code BEAM EU with ["Going Staff"](#)
- My talks cover a wide range, from [Benchmarking](#) to ["Functioning Among Humans"](#)
- I've been the main organizer of the [Ruby User Group Berlin](#) since 2012, a monthly meetup with between 20 and 120 attendees
- Long-time [Rails Girls](#) coach, giving introductions as well as mentoring a group from learning to program all the way through being senior engineers
- Head organizer JRubyConf 2015 & organizer eurucamp 2015, was a member of the program committee of GOTO Berlin 2014
- Co-created the [Berlin Code of Conduct](#) to ensure and promote a safe environment

# Education

## [Hasso Plattner Institute](#) / [Blekinge Institute of Technology](#) (Erasmus)

2008 — 2014

### Bachelor & Master in IT-Systems Engineering

Final grade: 1.2 (A), Specialization in Software Architecture, Internet Security, agile & globally distributed software development.

# Skills

## Engineering Practices

- agile Software Development (XP/Scrum/Kanban)
- Test Driven Development (ExUnit, RSpec)
- Benchmarking & Performance Improvements
- Observability

## Programming

- Functional Programming (Elixir, functional JavaScript)
- Object Oriented Programming (Ruby, Smalltalk)
- Web frameworks (Phoenix, Ruby on Rails)
- Web Technologies (HTML, CSS, JavaScript, JSON...)

## Leadership & Communication Skills

- Mentoring, Teaching & Presenting
- Scaling organizations & processes
- Run and moderate meetings such as Retrospectives
- Empathy
- Eye for process improvements and bottlenecks

## System Architecture

- Domain Driven Design
- Monoliths, microservices and the in-between
- Database Design (SQL)
- Design Patterns
- APIs (modules, REST, gRPC)

# Languages

## German

Native speaker

## English

Full working proficiency

## Swedish

Limited working proficiency

## French

Basic knowledge